

INTRODUCTION

A Crisis of Representation

This book, like many other works of Asian American literary criticism that preceded it, is about literature and politics. For better or worse, Asian American literary critics have generally approached Asian American literature as being symptomatic of ongoing historical concerns for Asian Americans—to read the literature, then, enables the critic to form political theses about the state of Asian America. I follow in this tradition because I believe literature matters, and in this book I insist that Asian American literature literally embodies the contradictions, conflicts, and potential future options of Asian American culture. I also argue that the way critics have tended to read this literature, as cultural works that demonstrate resistance or accommodation to the racist, sexist, and capitalist exploitation of Asian immigrants and Asian Americans, may be as much a reflection of the critics' professional histories, political priorities, and institutional locations as what may be found in historically framed close readings of the works themselves. Furthermore, the relationship of critics to literature parallels the relationship of Asian American intellectuals generally to Asian America. In other words, the theory of value that critics use to approach literature—what critics consider as the important things they should look for, encourage, and propagate—is shared by Asian American intellectuals as a whole as they seek to study, represent, and lead Asian America.

In many of the works that I examine in this book, resistance and accommodation are actually limited, polarizing options that do not sufficiently demonstrate the *flexible strategies* often chosen by authors and characters to navigate their political and ethical situations. This book negotiates between the flexibility and diversity of the texts on the one hand and the more rigid discourses of American racism and Asian American literary criticism that shape the reception and interpretation of the literature on the other hand. The ultimate irony in contemporary Asian American literary criticism is that a key flexible strategy used by Asian American literary criticism to enable its institutional survival in the university is often disavowed by Asian American literary criticism when it comes to evaluating the authors and characters of the literature. This strategy is one that Yen Le Espiritu calls “panethnic entrepreneurship” (*Asian American Panethnicity* 166). Panethnic entrepreneurs literally

capitalize upon their panethnic, or racial, identity. While we can see the post-1968 founding of Asian American literary criticism, and of Asian American studies in general, as a shift of Marxist-inspired political struggle from the “community” to the academy and from “real” politics to textual politics, the contemporary institutionalization and growth of Asian American literary criticism and Asian American studies is now equally beholden to the strategy of panethnic entrepreneurship, trading in the commodity of race.

Panethnic entrepreneurship is a product of the dialectical relationship between a capitalism that exploits race and the democratic struggles that have fought for greater racial and economic equality. This dialectic has transformed race and racial identity into focal points of organization and struggle, but it has also transformed race and racial identity into commodities. This dialectic and its result in panethnic entrepreneurship for Asian Americans can be traced to the nineteenth century, with the arrival of Chinese immigrants and their economic exploitation by American capital. The subsequent strategies that Chinese American authors such as Onoto Watanna and Sui Sin Far deployed included a deliberate blurring of the ethnic lines that separated European, Chinese, and Japanese Americans. These experiments with ethnic identity were not, however, articulated through a post-civil rights understanding about the potential of racial identity, or panethnicity, as a mode of political resistance. The emergence of a unique Asian American identity after 1968 was dependent upon such an understanding, but it also coincided with the maturation of a global capitalism that had the ability to turn even resistance into a commodity. In this contemporary moment of global capitalism, our modern version of panethnic entrepreneurship is a flexible strategy of pragmatic political struggle that blurs the clearcut, idealized distinction between resistance and accommodation that is the foundation of a self-defined Asian American identity stemming from the 1968 campus and community struggles.

As people who have participated in these struggles or as inheritors of the legacy of these struggles, Asian American critics do not generally read literature or look to the historical past in order to uncover examples of panethnic entrepreneurship and its effectiveness. The entire concept of panethnic entrepreneurship, with its basis in race as a product or function of economic capital and its connotations of “selling out,” is antithetical to Asian American academia specifically and to Asian American intellectuals generally. The Asian American intellectual class, defined here as inclusive of academics, artists, activists, and nonacademic critics, is a part of the realm of cultural production that finds its basis in what Pierre Bourdieu calls the economic world reversed (*Cultural Production* 29). In this reversed world, it is not economic capital, that is, money and its investment, that matters as much as *symbolic* capital, other things besides money that we invest with value and which eventually generate an economic return. For the Asian American intellectual class, it is racial identity as a mode

of resistance to capitalist exploitation that accrues symbolic rather than economic capital. In simple terms, we as academics or intellectuals make very little economic capital, *relative* to something like the world of corporations, but this is partially a function of our investment in the idea of Asian America as a place of resistance to capitalist exploitation. In the case of Asian American studies specifically, while it is obviously a worthy political and intellectual endeavor in many ways, it is also an enterprise of panethnic entrepreneurship within academia, reaping the particular and peculiar rewards of academia by using the symbolic capital of race and resistance.¹

In writing this book, I aim to read Asian American literature *for* its flexible strategies that concern struggle, survival, and possible assimilation, which means often reading *against* the rigid assumptions of a newly institutionalized Asian American literary criticism that disavows panethnic entrepreneurship. In a similar vein, Jinqi Ling argues that Asian American literary critics often overlook the fact that Asian American literary texts engage in a process of “negotiation” (*Narrating Nationalisms* 11), whereby “these texts’ ideological tendencies and formal characteristics, as well as the specific forms of their social imagination, were shaped not by any single determinant but rather by the complex interplay between authorial design, available social space, and accessible cultural resources” (30). Ling attributes the tendency of contemporary Asian American literary criticism to misread early Asian American literary texts as being ideologically or textually simple to the criticism’s poststructuralist sympathies. Expanding upon Ling, I propose here that the problem of misreading is much graver, and stems from an ideological rigidity in the criticism itself. I argue that the criticism tends to read for signs of resistance or accommodation because critics are reacting to the demands of American racism, which have historically treated Asian Americans as the bad subject to be punished or expelled or as the model minority to be included or exploited for complicity. At the same time, the criticism does not recognize how such a critical predisposition resonates with the commodification of race and the practices of panethnic entrepreneurship within the academy. Such a lack of recognition may indeed be a function of disavowing uncomfortable contradictions. The critical misreading of the texts that results becomes emblematic of the more significant misreading that Asian American intellectuals are engaged in when it comes to Asian America as a whole.

To support these contentions about the political unconscious of Asian American critical practice, I read Asian American literature for its representations of the body, because these representations collectively constitute the most consistent form of political consciousness in the literature. They are commentaries upon the troubled place of Asian Americans in the American body politic and upon the nature of an Asian American body politic as well. For Asian American writers, a deep interest in representing the body, through a variety of fashions and over a range of time and situations, is almost

always evident in the literature. This is not surprising given the way that dominant American society has historically used derogatory, bodily centered representations of Asians and Asian Americans in order to facilitate capitalist exploitation and foment racial hatred. Asian American writers, as a result, have turned to the representation of the body as a method of exploring and possibly countering the consequences of such exploitation and hatred. Their literature contains a history of representations of the body that develops in relation to the changing status of the Asian American body politic in the United States during the past century. As this status changes, so do the representations of the body, resulting in the domination of particular kinds of bodies in the literature at different historical moments. These changing bodies constitute a rhetoric of the body that has existed since the 1899 publication of Onoto Watanna's *Miss Numè of Japan*, the first novel written by an Asian American, and extends to 1999, with the publication of Lois-Ann Yamanaka's *Heads by Harry*, the last novel I consider in this book. As we shall see, by its very nature the Asian American body politic is defined not only by race and class—the traditional intellectual lenses of Asian American studies—but also, simultaneously, by gender and sexuality, to such an extent that Asian American writers, male and female, often articulate their concerns about race and class *through* gender and sexuality. As Rachel Lee argues, “Gender and sexuality remain instrumental to the ways in which Asian American writers conceive of and write about ‘America’” (*The Americas* 3).

The fact that the Asian American body is composed simultaneously through race, class, gender, and sexuality has become an accepted truism of Asian American critical practice, exemplified in Lisa Lowe's justly famous characterization of the Asian American body politic as being marked by “heterogeneity, hybridity, multiplicity” (*Immigrant Acts* 60). For the most part, however, Asian American critics have been concerned with the *demographic* heterogeneity of the Asian American body politic and not with its *ideological* heterogeneity, the concern of this book. (Ideological heterogeneity should not be mistaken, of course, for *class* heterogeneity, which most Asian American intellectuals are willing to acknowledge.) While American racism's focus on the body has meant that the representation of the body remains as a trace of political consciousness in almost all Asian American literary works, this does not mean that there is a predetermined ideological orientation to the works or that an ideological consensus can be found in them. In contrast, Asian American critics tend to see texts as demonstrating either resistance or accommodation to American racism. Not willing to read for ideological heterogeneity, the critics betray their own ideological rigidity. The primary consequence of such rigidity is that critics tend to evaluate resistance as positive and accommodation as negative, without questioning the reductiveness of such evaluations. Part of this critical consensus stems from the fact that although this century-long span of 1899 to 1999 has

witnessed significant changes for the roles and perceptions of Asian Americans, it has also witnessed a noticeable and important *lack* of change that concerns the *basic* political representations of Asian Americans. In the past and in the present, dominant American society has tended to cast Asian Americans in one of two ways: as an inevitably foreign threat (the “bad subject”) or as an exemplary example of domestic integration—the “model minority.” Given this bifurcated representation of Asian Americans, we might assume that resistance and accommodation, bifurcated responses, are the most commonplace categories of action for Asian Americans. It is my argument, of course, that this is not the case, and the flexible strategies exhibited by Asian American authors and literary characters are testimony to the ways Asian Americans in general pick and choose their tactics of struggle, survival, and possible assimilation. The fact that Asian American studies specifically, and Asian American intellectuals in general, prioritize resistance and condemn accommodation stems from the moment of 1968, when Asian American intellectuals self-consciously formed “Asian America.”

The year 1968 is historically convenient and memorable but not quite adequate in encompassing previous or subsequent efforts to unify diverse Asian ethnicities into one political and cultural bloc. Nevertheless, I proceed from this time because it forms a landmark in the self-definition of the most influential portion of the Asian American intellectual class, who identify this year as critical because it allows for a unification of political potential over cultural diversity. In short, 1968 forms a clear moment of *self-articulation* on the part of Asian American intellectuals that concerns the constitution of an Asian American body politic as a diverse but unified group engaged in a struggle for racial equality. The belief in racial equality, or specifically the idea that race should not be used to exploit people politically and economically, is probably the *only* safe description of any political consensus in Asian America today.² While one can conjecture that the mainstream Asian American intellectual class generally favors proactive methods and ideologies for creating a situation of both racial and economic equality, it is unclear if there is a consensus regarding what those methods and ideologies are and what is meant by “equality.” In addition, as the visibility of Asian Americans on the American political landscape has increased in the past thirty years, the political and intellectual leadership of Asian America has been challenged in practice by the diversity of its constituents, initiating a *crisis of representation* in the Asian American body politic that has not yet been fully recognized by the leadership but has exploded in incidents such as the controversy over Lois-Ann Yamanaka’s novel *Blu’s Hanging*.

In 1998 the Association for Asian American Studies decided to award its annual prize for literary merit to *Blu’s Hanging*, immediately igniting a firestorm that almost destroyed the Association. *Blu’s Hanging* is a novel that centers on a local Japanese family living in Hawaii’s multiethnic, class-

stratified society. Part of the novel depicts the molestation and rape of a local Japanese boy, Blu, by a young man of mixed Filipino and Japanese ancestry, Uncle Paulo, who also has incestuous sexual relations with his pubescent nieces. The cycle of violence and victimization initiated by Uncle Paulo continues with the nieces, who not only take sadistic pleasure in torturing and killing cats but also are actually responsible for Blu's sexual initiation, prior to his molestation and rape. Before and during the Association's annual meeting, Yamanaka's novel became the target of concerted protests by Filipinos and their supporters over allegations that concerned the book's racist depictions of Filipinos. The Association was divided between the supporters of these allegations and those who argued that the protests were attempts at censorship.³ During the annual meeting, as the Association's membership discussed revoking the award (which they eventually did), the Association's board of directors resigned en masse—with one exception—for fear of assuming personal legal responsibility over the renunciation of the award, since the Association was neither incorporated nor insured.

Blu's Hanging clearly demonstrates the importance of the body and its representation in both literature and politics. The representation of the body becomes immediately apparent when we remember that the controversy is focused on a sexual crime that occurs in a novel generally concerned with the problems of female adolescence and sexual consciousness in a class- and ethnic- conflicted setting. It is this crime centered on the body that leads to the controversy over the nature of the Asian American body politic itself. One aspect of this controversy concerns the ethnic diversity of Asian America and how it might contradict a unified Asian American political front. The problem of ethnic diversity among Asian Americans, considered in isolation, may lead us to turn to a pluralist ideology of interest-group negotiation, resolved by the motto *e pluribus unum*, as a solution. The controversy ignited by Yamanaka's novel, however, signifies a graver problem than ethnic diversity for Asian America. That greater problem is *ideological* diversity, and it threatens the ability of Asian America to represent itself in a unified fashion. The particular way in which this crisis of representation over ideological diversity takes place in the controversy centers on the following question: should the Association be committed to a model of equitable political representation for all its constituent ethnicities, or should it be committed to a model of free speech and artistic freedom? These choices, while crudely articulated here, nevertheless characterize the positions adopted by the opposing sides in the controversy.

One of the ironies in the controversy was that Asian American intellectuals, artists included, have rarely found it problematic to speak out against anti-Asian racism in American art, most memorably in protests directed against the Broadway musical *Miss Saigon*.⁴ Yet, in the Yamanaka controversy, we find Yamanaka's defenders, including many artists, returning to the same language of artistic freedom

deployed by *Miss Saigon*'s producers. The case of *Miss Saigon* demonstrates that anti-Asian racism makes us all Asian, rather than singularly ethnic, and that Asian America as a category or identity is effective in a *defensive* posture. In contrast, from the perspective of Yamanaka's defenders, the issue of possible prejudice becomes purely a problem for Filipinos and cultural philistines who do not understand literary technique and artistic freedom. In other words, when prejudice is intraethnic rather than racial, the ability of Asian America to articulate a cohesive identity is fractured. Asian America, born from a dialectic of racism and antiracism, may not in the end be very effective in presenting an *offensive* posture in order to address issues beyond racial discrimination. We can understand the implications of the Yamanaka controversy when we consider the larger issue of Asian American demographics and what it entails politically. As Asian America has witnessed the growth of its power in the past thirty years due to a rising population and increased political organization, it has also witnessed the growth of a demographically diverse population that is also ideologically diverse due to its wide range of origins and points of entry into American society.

In the past and to some extent in the present, Asian American intellectual and political leadership could count on the threat of racism to unify the Asian American population. This racism often expressed itself through capitalist exploitation or working-class rivalry. Therefore, antiracist positions advanced by the leadership often had anticapitalist connotations. In the contemporary moment, however, American and global capitalism is succeeding in the *reification* of Asian American culture, despite the best efforts of Asian American intellectuals. Reification transforms human relationships into the relationships between things, originally made by humans but now seemingly independent (and "imagined as originally independent" [Bottomore 462]).⁵ Thus the contemporary Asian American identity that has allowed Asian Americans to participate in American politics—frequently as an anticapitalist force—has now also become a thing, a commodity, to be marketed and consumed. While Asian American political identity has enabled political resistance against racism and capitalist exploitation, Asian American cultural identity in the present moment furthers the aims of capitalism because Asian American cultural identity—an Asian American *lifestyle*—is both a commodity and a market at the same time.⁶

As a consequence, Asian American intellectuals who have traditionally opposed reification and the way capitalism has historically used racial differences to exploit Asian American populations must now confront Asian American populations that find in this racialized capitalism a positive form of cultural exploitation. Asian American intellectuals have not seriously explored *either* the reality that Asian American identity is a commodity *or* the positive possibilities that such commodification enables. In other words, if Asian American intellectuals were to investigate the commodification of

Asian American identity, they may be predictable in doing so by examining *only* its negative consequences. Yet it may be the case that in the next few decades some of the most important Asian Americans, in terms of transforming American perceptions of Asian Americans, will not only be Asian American intellectuals but also Asian Americans who are capitalists or who are unabashed panethnic entrepreneurs. An example of the former is the Internet and high-tech entrepreneur, who is destroying the stereotype of the Asian American as technician and middle manager; examples of the latter are the creators of *A. Magazine*, which combines a liberal political and cultural slant with a slick marketing of fashion, technology, culture, and lifestyle to upwardly mobile, highly educated, cosmopolitan young Asian Americans. Regardless of what one thinks of the *kinds* of achievements these Asian Americans are making or whether it is worthwhile to reform American capitalism to be inclusive of Asian Americans, it is inarguable that such achievements have a radical and material impact on Asian American culture. These achievements enable greater political and cultural participation in American society for many Asian Americans—including Asian American intellectuals.

This transformation of racialized capitalism, from a totally negative exploitation of race through the mid-twentieth century to its partially positive exploitation today, finds its roots in the intersection of racialized capitalism with American pluralist democracy. In order to obtain political voice and economic equality, Asian Americans found themselves forced to participate in a pluralist political system that privileges representation by large political interests, one of the most noticeable being, after the civil rights movement, racially defined groups. Political representation through race, taking the form of multiculturalism, has transformed minority racial identities from being stigmatized to celebrated, at least on the level of the *representative* (if not necessarily the *represented*). This celebration of race in the form of pluralist political and cultural representation has also meant that racial identity has become a cultural icon and commodity, in variable ways for different racial populations. For Asian Americans, this transformation of race into a cultural icon and commodity in the marketplace of multiculturalism is embodied in the model minority. The model minority is an identity that is testimony to the Asian American ability to be good citizen, productive worker, reliable consumer, and member of a niche lifestyle suitable for capitalist exploitation. The model minority is the vehicle of entry for a racial population not only into American capitalism but also into American politics—indeed, the two go hand in hand.

For Asian America, therefore, a significant tension exists between an attraction to the marketplace of multiculturalism, represented by the model minority, and a distrust of or outright resistance to capitalism, represented by the mainstream of the Asian American intellectual class. This ideological conflict within Asian America is a problem for the Asian American communities and signifies that

Asian America is and will be in a state of flux that is part of the process of racial formation. Racial formation in the United States has saturated racial identities with political meanings, although that does not mean that the Asian American body politic is inherently oppositional to a political order based upon racial differentiation, class stratification, and the contradictory tensions between democracy and capitalism. Racial formation is an aspect of *hegemony* in the United States. Hegemony is the political process by which the dominant class of a society extracts the political consensus of subordinate classes whose interests may be contradicted by that dominant class. As an aspect of hegemony, then, contemporary racial identities involve some type of consensus to the dominant political order. Therefore, Asian America is not simply or only a mode of opposition to this order. It also participates in political struggles over the meaning of citizenship and subjectivity within the American body politic, assuming a variety of possible positions that range from opposition and contestation to acquiescence and consensus with the dominant body politic.

Asian American intellectuals, however, have been most interested in representing themselves and the object of their study—Asian America—as sites of political and cultural contestation against forms of racial and class hierarchy integral to American society.⁷ We have not been as interested in critiquing how we ourselves may be obscuring differences of power within Asian America or the limitations to our own theory and practice that ensue from an ideological belief that Asian America is *only* a place of ethnic consensus and resistance to an inherently exploitative or destructive capitalism. It is my belief that for Asian American intellectual work to grow in vitality not only must it continue the vital task of criticizing American society's methods of racial and class domination, but it must also engage in a self-critique that results in an understanding of Asian America's limits.⁸ I am not alone in this belief, for there is also a significant, if minor, strand of thought among Asian American intellectuals that articulates a similar concern about these limits. Interestingly, many—although far from all—of these intellectuals are of Filipino and South Asian descent, suggesting that the theoretical concerns they and I have about the theoretical and political consensus within Asian American intellectual work is at least partially a product of a sense of intellectual and ethnic exclusion from an Asian American coalition whose concerns and priorities have been shaped by the historical domination of intellectuals who come primarily, although not exclusively, from Japanese and Chinese American backgrounds.⁹ It is important for me to acknowledge, however, that when I speak of Asian American intellectuals in this fashion, I do so in complete recognition of how the work of an earlier generation has enabled my own. The list of artists and academics I am indebted to is lengthy, and their work is cited throughout this book as a gesture to the foundations they have built and upon which this work is constructed. Their commitment to a model of intellectual work as political contestation, which

has directly contributed to the formation of Asian America and the creation of Asian American studies, has made my own critique possible.

What I propose in my critique is that the challenge for Asian American intellectuals is to reconsider conventional assumptions that concern race and its formation without at the same time engaging in a reactionary “retreat from race,” simply because racial identity is a contradiction.¹⁰ Asian America as an identity and focal point for alliances and cultural formation has proven to be useful and productive in many ways, allowing for the articulation of genuine dissent with the racial and class politics of the United States. It has also allowed, arguably, the formation of an exciting, hybrid culture that is first and foremost Asian American, rather than ethnically specific. While it is critical for us to acknowledge that Asian America is an outcome of radical social movements that were opposed to capitalism and its excesses, we must not forget that in the contemporary moment Asian America is also useful to capital through racial formation. Through race in its contemporary form, the state is able to identify populations and select representatives for a pluralist system of government that is committed to propagating capitalism, which in its turn transforms Asian American identity into both a lifestyle commodity and a market for that commodity. Asian American identity and American capitalism are thus engaged in a dialectical relationship of mutual transformation. For Asian American academics, this intersection of race and capitalism is manifest in our own disavowed practice as panethnic entrepreneurs; while entrepreneurial practice allows us to further our existence within the academy, the disavowal of such a practice fundamentally shapes our theoretical views, predisposing us to an ideological rigidity that we ourselves do not practice professionally and that is difficult to see in the Asian American historical and literary past. In the relationship between Asian American literature and Asian American literary criticism, we thus witness a tension between flexibility and rigidity, a tension that also marks this book as it traces that relationship. Another important moment of tension and contradiction for Asian American intellectuals and their relationship to both Asian America and the American nation is marked by pluralism. Pluralism is a hallmark of American nation and culture that Asian American intellectuals often like to assail because it is a form of political organization that represents a vast group of constituencies under a singular identity that is inadequate in terms of fully addressing the cultural, political, and class heterogeneity of American populations. Ironically, as Susan Koshy demonstrates, even as Asian American intellectuals reject American pluralism, they implicitly endorse it for Asian America as a necessary strategy that enables Asian American political agency, unifying a diverse set of ethnicities under a singular racial label (315–

317). This pluralist Asian America then forms both the horizon of intellectual consensus for Asian American intellectuals and the critical limit to our ability to think through the problem of race, gender, and capital.

RACIAL FORMATION AND THE BODY POLITIC

I have spoken repeatedly of the Asian American intellectual class and its consensus regarding the role of Asian Americans in the American body politic, as if this class is homogeneous, especially in relation to a diverse Asian America. I will argue that unlike Asian America as a whole, the contemporary Asian American intellectual class—what I have referred to as the *mainstream* class—does indeed exhibit a much higher degree of ideological homogeneity. It can at least be characterized as being left-of-center, with the wide range of possibilities from liberal to Marxist that is implied, and it can at least be characterized as being invested in the value of an Asian American identity. This last point is particularly important to establish, because it separates the class I am talking about from those intellectuals *who only happen to be Asian American* but either do not recognize the importance of such a classification or disagree with that classification to begin with. An example of such an intellectual would be the neoconservative Dinesh D’Souza; since many neoconservatives are already inclined to reject racial classification and identity, they are already not, by definition, part of a self-identified Asian American intellectual class. Another example of such intellectuals—if we include political leaders among such a classification—is the Chinese American parents who have sued to end affirmative action in Bay Area high schools like Lowell. Their political efforts are a precursor of what will come; the moment when these Chinese American parents, or others like them, start articulating their struggle as an Asian American one will be a critical point in the articulation of an Asian American neoconservatism that will force the intellectual and political leadership of Asian America to recognize a challenge to its consensus. There are already such people as Asian American neoconservatives, of course, who embrace both neoconservative ideology and Asian American identity, but they exist as an emergent group whose exceptional status *at the present moment* proves the rule of Asian American intellectual consensus. Furthermore, what is particularly provocative about the prospect of Asian American neoconservative political leadership is their potential ability to lay claim to the mantle of what Antonio Gramsci calls the “organic intellectual”—the intellectual of the people, a position to which mainstream Asian American intellectuals now generally aspire.¹¹

In this next section, I will focus specifically on an important subset of this mainstream class, Asian American academics, who have presented the most cogent theories that concern the formation of

Asian America and its political function. The theories presented by Asian American academics and the actual practice of Asian American communities are oftentimes contradictory, as we can see in the case of academics and their community in the university. Within the academy, it is not only the case that the theories Asian American studies deploys to analyze its object (re)create that object in important ways, but they also serve to (re)create Asian American studies itself, as David Li argues:

[Asian American knowledge production] cannot take place without the (re)production of capital and capitalistic social relations; neither can it be indifferent to the academy's system of (e)valuation. . . . We may say that Asian American studies as a political instrument of radical social transformation has been successful only to the extent that it has constituted itself as an academic discipline and has thus ensured a limited intellectual and racial representation within the academy. (201)¹²

Thus the dilemma that Asian American studies faces is that its oppositional theories are the currency that enables its institutionalization and survival. In the context of Asian American literary criticism in particular, Sau-ling C. Wong also notes that Asian American literature is an “emergent and evolving textual coalition whose interests it is the business of a professional coalition of Asian American critics to promote” (*Reading Asian American Literature* 9). Therefore, while Asian American literary critics have striven to be at the forefront of political consciousness in Asian American studies, they are also invested in the visibility and value of Asian American literature as the proof of their own professional usefulness to the academy and the English department. While Asian American studies is not unique in this professionalization, what is significant is the *contradiction* between the radical intellectual goals of Asian American studies and its institutional location.¹³ Furthermore, what is important about acknowledging that Asian American studies is a *business* is the implications that this has for understanding the theoretical practice of Asian American studies, built simultaneously upon the critique of racist capitalism and the disavowal of its own capitalist practice. The idealism that characterizes such a disavowal is then embedded in the critics' view of the past and their object of study; therefore, this study follows Rey Chow's call for an “ethics after idealism.”

For Asian American intellectuals, an ethics of intellectual inquiry and political practice that rejects the idealization of both racial identity and political resistance is necessary in order to confront the dilemma of confrontation and institutionalization that marks the trajectory of racial formation and the shaping of racial communities, as argued in the influential work of Michael Omi and Howard Winant.

¹⁴ This trajectory follows an arc that moves from a moment of unstable equilibrium between races to a contestation by a racial minority against racial exclusion or oppression, followed by the accommodation and inclusion of the minority's concerns on the part of the state, leading to a period of

unstable equilibrium between the state and the minority. The last moment of unstable equilibrium ended with the crisis brought about by the civil rights movement, a crisis finally brought under control by the state in the 1970s, shifting the United States to a new period of unstable equilibrium in which we are still living. In this state of equilibrium, racial difference is no longer *principally* policed by violent coercion (although that is still used) but is instead primarily maintained and negotiated through the consent of racial minorities. Omi and Winant borrow the term “hegemony” from Antonio Gramsci in order to characterize the post-civil rights era and argue that “hegemony operates by including its subjects, incorporating its opposition” (Omi and Winant 68). Part of that incorporation is the bureaucratization of race through civil rights, the census, and affirmative action. While race existed as a bureaucratic, political category before 1964, it also became, subsequent to 1964, a method of charting inequality and state-mandated opportunity. Asian Americans became increasingly aware of their identity as a racial group, both as defined by the state and in self-defined methods.¹⁵ Asian American studies is one of those self-defined methods, and the contemporary state of Asian American studies in this moment of unstable equilibrium is marked by both pragmatism, where its radical views have been domesticated in the name of institutional survival and respectability, and reaction, where the actions of past Asian Americans are evaluated through the lenses of either resistance or accommodation, the bifurcated responses to American racism’s desire to either suppress or incorporate Asian Americans.

Contemporary Asian America, as a product of racial formation that is embraced by the state, also reproduces some of the state’s features, which is inevitable under the process of political consensus that characterizes the contemporary moment. What is *not inevitable*, however, is the disavowal of that reproduction on the part of Asian American intellectuals. This disavowal is an ironic example of an “articulate silence” deployed by Asian American intellectuals and can be witnessed in their adoption of the panethnic strategy in order to attain a greater degree of political influence in the United States’ pluralist system of representation.¹⁶ Pluralism as a system premised upon a hierarchy of representatives and those they represent favors interest groups and spokespersons or organizations, and panethnicity gathers the heterogeneous communities of immigrants and citizens of Asian descent into one identifiable body. The system of pluralistic representation in the Asian American context has promoted the leadership of middle-class professionals for panethnic groups, so that as Yen Le Espiritu writes, “Pan-Asian ethnicity has come to signify the ‘bourgeois’ politics of the professionals, lobbyists, and politicians” (*Asian American Panethnicity* 53).¹⁷ Asian America, therefore, is capable of exercising the same rhetoric of pluralism that the American state does, promising equality but practicing hierarchy when it comes to dealing with various Asian ethnic groups with conflicting

interests.¹⁸ This translates into the Asian American panethnic coalition being built upon an alliance of politically unequal partners—those who represent and those who are represented. Given the history of Asian immigration, with different ethnic groups arriving at different times with different advantages or disadvantages, this has meant that older, more established ethnic groups such as the Chinese and Japanese have produced more of the leadership of the community. They have also had the opportunity to establish a higher level of economic success on the average, and casual observers may draw a correlation between economic success and particular ethnic identities, so that economic inequality within Asian America has often seemed to be a function of ethnic difference.¹⁹ Ethnic difference in and of itself, however, does not constitute a serious problem for a panethnic coalition, because, as Espiritu notes throughout *Asian American Panethnicity*, panethnic coalitions can exist comfortably with such difference. The critical factor in helping to determine unity or disunity in a panethnic coalition is class homogeneity or the lack thereof.

The fact that the middle class has an investment in pluralism signifies that pluralism allows them economic and political access and that it contributes to the stability of the nation and its overall economic health by alleviating racial conflict through ethnic inclusion. In the pluralist model, the cultural inclusion of a minority within the nation is a difficult but attainable goal, achievable over time. This premise undergirds multiculturalism, which becomes what Slavoj Žižek calls the “cultural logic of multinational capitalism.”²⁰ To the extent that Asian America replicates the pluralistic principle of multiculturalism in a capitalist society, it, too, consents to what Paul Ong, Edna Bonacich, and Lucie Cheng argue is the most basic principle or “goal of the state”: “to protect and enhance profit” (7).²¹ Within a pluralist Asian America that repeats the rhetoric of the state, mutable ethnic differences can be overcome to achieve a cohesive Asian American identity that facilitates political and economic representation by the ethnic middle class. In the interests of such representation, proponents of Asian American identity may suppress other contradictory issues. Peter Kwong argues that as a result of this suppression, Asian American panethnicity is a “reactive one” whose “union is merely a pragmatic alliance” of different groups; “proponents of Asian panethnicity, understandably, want to stress the collective attributes to reinforce this unity and avoid issues, such as class, that might be divisive” (76).²²

A refusal on the part of Asian American studies to investigate such divisions and internal differences accelerates the dialectical relationship between race and capitalism, whereby racial identity is initially demonized by dominant society at least partially in order to facilitate economic exploitation, asserted as a strategy of political survival by the subordinate group and then ironically transformed into an idealized commodity. This commodification has already taken place to some

extent, as we can see that within academia Asian American culture is something that academics not only study but also trade in as a form of symbolic capital. For Bourdieu, “‘Symbolic capital’ is to be understood as economic or political capital that is disavowed, misrecognized and thereby recognized, hence legitimate, a ‘credit’ which, under certain conditions, and always in the long run, guarantees ‘economic’ profits” (*Cultural Production* 75). These profits result even though, ironically, Asian American academic work is generally geared toward criticism of the dominant order. Late capitalism—in this case embodied in the university—is capable of accommodating even rebellion, transforming acts of cultural and political resistance into commodities. Distinguishing economic from symbolic capital enables us to recognize the subtle process of rebellion and reward that is a part of bourgeois society and its efforts to domesticate dissent through commodifying it.²³ Acknowledging the significance of symbolic capital for Asian America on our part is important because it demonstrates the contradictory location of Asian American intellectual work—contradictory because it is both antagonistic to and in some cases rewarded by capitalism.²⁴

For Asian American culture, one particular object invested with both symbolic and economic capital is the body. In this book, I use the term “body politic” to describe the vast formal entity that arises in the literature when authors use the bodies of their narrators or characters to represent Asian Americans and their collective relationship to both nation and capital.²⁵ Thus bodies in Asian American literature are never just individually significant but point instead to the intersecting relationships of race, class, gender, and sexuality that ascribe meaning and substance to the very idea of an *Asian American* body in the first place (versus the normative, unmarked body of dominant American culture). These intersecting relationships mark the Asian American body as not just *a* cultural product but “*the* cultural product” (Grosz 23).²⁶ I would also add that the Asian American body is a historical product, and the condensation of culture and history in the Asian American body makes it a critical place to conduct any inquiry into the formation of Asian America. The Asian American body politic as a term, a formal entity, speaks to the fact that merely invoking the identity “Asian American” erases the distinction between the individual and the collective, gesturing instead to the United States’ long history of treating Asian Americans as an indistinguishable group rather than as an aggregate of individuals—hence inevitably politicizing them and their bodies. This treatment of Asian Americans as a racial other proceeded in two stages, according to David Li, who characterizes the distinction between the earlier period of exclusion and marginalization and the contemporary moment as a shift from “Oriental alienation” to “Asian abjection,” in which Asian Americans are regarded initially as inassimilable aliens and then, subsequent to World War II, as legally acceptable but culturally inassimilable foreigners.²⁷ Usually these relationships were ones of sexual, economic,

and physical threat or servitude on the part of Asians, with threat and servitude being the two sides of the same essential stereotype concerning the “Oriental.”²⁸ It is through this rhetoric of demonization, marginalization, and exclusion that Asian Americans are created as a separate and dangerous body politic within the United States—as a cancerous entity within the American body politic.²⁹ Asian American culture is characterized by this constant tension between American racism’s efforts to construct Asians as a singular body and the Asian American response that there are instead multiple ones. American racism’s effort to create a singular Asian American body also works in conjunction with American political economy’s contradictory effort to deny the existence of *white* bodies and enforce, instead, a legal reliance upon abstract and bodiless persons.³⁰ This “rhetoric of bodily denial” (Sánchez-Eppler 140) serves to create an unmarked subject of the law who is in practice masculine and white while also creating its other, a marked subject whose differences are rendered visible and corporeal. The creation of the Asian marked subject serves to unify the definition of the American citizen “against the Asian immigrant, legally, economically, and culturally” (Lowe, *Immigrant Acts* 4), sanctioning the unity of an American body politic through the formation of a racial other.

In response, Asian ethnic groups cohered as their own bodies politic, unifying and organizing around their scant ethnic numbers until mass mobilization and consciousness by these ethnic groups was made possible in the late 1960s. Asian America was thus created from the damage inflicted upon Asian immigrants and their descendants by racial discourse in the United States, a discourse that also articulated itself through the demands of heterosexual patriarchy and class exploitation. For the new Asian Americans to proclaim their unique identity as an American population was also for them to lay claim to the humanity of their individual bodies and to the legitimacy of their collective political body. The Asian American body politic is composed of both this vast array of individual bodies and the collective body they form together. This collective body, shaped through both the negative, exclusionary and objectifying pressure of American racism and the positive will of political agency on the part of these negatively identified populations, allows the aggregate of individuals to articulate their voice and be heard within the American political system. At the same time as collective racial identity allows participation in political pluralism, it also ironically allows its own commodification in the post-1968 moment. Racial identity as commodity supplements the self that has been damaged by racial difference and discrimination, overt or covert in its manifestations.³¹ In such a scenario, the act of consumption serves to supplement the self, with the commodity being an “object of desire” that represents “something lacking” (Falk 131). In this case, what is lacking for people of color as a result

of racism is a sense of a whole identity. There are implications, of course, for Asian American identity as we know it today if anti-Asian racism subsides or changes—namely, that Asian American identity may no longer be necessary or at least no longer as compelling for political mobilization.

The efforts to mobilize an Asian American movement around a rehabilitated body constitute a body project on the part of some panethnic entrepreneurs, who seek to turn the body from being negatively marked by a history of racist signification to being positively marked and marketable in the arena of multiethnic identification and consumption.³² While the critics who have dealt with the body as a project have focused their attention upon methods such as plastic surgery, exercise, and fashion, race as a form of signification through racial formation is also a method for transforming the body symbolically.³³ Certainly the contemporary concept of Asian America is a product of the efforts of intellectuals to symbolically rework the body that was stigmatized by American racial discourse as alien and threatening. The cultural (re)signification of the body is thus an important component of body projects in general and racially formed bodies in particular, and within the realm of literature-as-culture the body has been of great significance. Peter Brooks claims that beginning in the eighteenth century, “modern narratives appear to produce a semioticization of the body, which is matched by a somatization of story: a claim that the body must be a source and a locus of meanings, and that stories cannot be told without making the body a prime vehicle of narrative signification” (*Body Work* xii). With race, the semioticization of the body and somatization of story achieves a particular meaning, as we can see in the well-documented depictions of Asians and Asian Americans by Europeans and European Americans.³⁴ In Asian American literature and arguably in other forms of Asian American culture, there is also an intense focus upon the methods of semioticization and somatization. Asian American literature attempts to resignify the body, inherently assuming its status as a politicized body, and makes the body itself a “prime vehicle of narrative signification” that produces different meanings at different historical periods. The history of the Asian American body politic in Asian American literature is an uneven one, exhibiting traces of the contradictory policies of the United States toward Asian immigrants and Asia. This history is also an ideologically unpredictable one, rife as it is with explicit examples of ethnic and panethnic entrepreneurship and the deployment of flexible strategies that resist easy categorization into either resistance or accommodation.

Furthermore, what we find in the literature is not a teleological development of the body but instead the development of multiple versions of bodily signification that exist simultaneously, particularly with the increasing demographic diversification of Asian America. While a recognition of such multiplicity may be a cause of celebration for some in Asian America, it is a crisis of representation for others. The crisis in the Asian American body politic—both the collective one and the individual

one—is part of a larger social crisis. The proliferation of discussions that concern the nature, constitution, and interpretation of the body indicates this larger social crisis, because “when we see a culture self-consciously defining bodies, it is already in trouble” (Hyde 11). The destabilization of the body is an indicator of our changing perceptions concerning the natural state of the body, as advances in medical science and social mores and changes in various kinds of cultural and political definitions of the body allow people increased control over the appearance, production, reception, and interpretation of their bodies.³⁵ Not surprisingly, the destabilization of the body has led to vigorous attempts to restabilize it, and in the realm of race, racial advocates have struggled to propose a unified and cohesive definition of the racial body politic. Asian America has endeavored to develop a consensus about the nature of its body politic, and the panethnic consensus it has achieved in recent years has been for the most part one that resonates with the pluralist consensus already found in American culture. It is not the resonance with pluralism that should necessarily bother us, of course, since it is to some extent inevitable, but the contradiction that this poses with the actual diversity of Asian America’s constituents.

POLITICAL CONSENSUS AND DETERRITORIALIZATION

Mari Matsuda’s argument in *Where Is Your Body?* illustrates this contradictory attempt at defining a unified Asian American body politic and hence furthering its ability to exercise political power through consensus. Matsuda argues that in the contemporary period we have witnessed the rise of the “Asian American Racial Bourgeoisie.” Matsuda is profoundly disturbed by the phenomenon of a racial bourgeoisie descended from the revolutionary origins of Asian America, and she notes, in language only slightly less provocative than Frank Chin’s that concerns “real” and “fake” Asians, that “not everyone with an Asian surname is in fact Asian within the meaning of our constructed coalition. To speak plainly, there are some people of Asian descent we might not embrace as representing our community, even if they were elected to Congress. If Asian-American [*sic*] identity is constructed, and constructed in part by a history of activism, then issues do define us” (177).³⁶ Matsuda’s position reveals the contradiction that constitutes Asian America, torn between its imposed construction as an abject racial identity and its self-construction as radical political identity. Both constructions imply a type of acceptable identity, delimited in the former instance by social notions of race and in the latter instance by political notions of ideological legitimacy. Antiracism compels what Espiritu calls a “reactive solidarity” among Asian Americans to protect themselves against violence, but that solidarity of identity and ideology breaks down in the contemporary period of increasing assimilation

and lessening violence—at least for the middle class that constitutes Asian American panethnic leadership. Unless Asian Americans agree to the highly unlikely possibility of formally policing their identity, the political and cultural reality for Asian America is a new era of internal conflicts that stem from the recently recognized reality of Asian America becoming what Susan Koshy calls a deterritorialized ethnicity.

A territorialized ethnicity is one that is invested in the territory of the nation, the attendant language of nationalist identification and assimilation, and the commodification of racial identity that is now a part of U.S. late capitalism's acceptance of multiculturalism. Asian American intellectuals are ambivalent about the ideology of the territorialized ethnicity, embodied in the model minority, which they see as a mode of “false consciousness” that misrecognizes the ideological position of Asian Americans in American society.³⁷ At the same time, Asian Americans as a territorialized ethnicity are at least unified in their political focus upon assimilation and overcoming the obstacles of racism and exclusion, and Asian American intellectuals stand relatively unified behind such a focus. The deterritorialization of ethnicity, in contrast, is emblematic of even more complicated ideological conflicts that Asian America faces. Koshy argues that the deterritorialization of ethnicity stems from the changing nature of Asian immigration and identification, which increasingly is no longer defined in the traditional model of pluralism and assimilation that undergirds Asian American literary criticism and American ethnic literary criticism embodied in the work of scholars such as Werner Sollors. The assimilationist paradigm of descent and consent in Sollors's work and the imperative to claim an American identity found in many accounts of Asian American literature are no longer necessarily the dominant motivations of new immigrant populations. For them, “ethnicity metamorphoses at multiple sites of transit, return, and arrival in the movement between and within nations; it can no longer be defined through the negotiation between origin and destination” (Koshy 338). Without the compelling narrative of assimilation and political resistance against exclusion, the possibilities for uniting Asian America over its heterogeneous constitution rapidly begin to fracture.³⁸

This fracturing is especially evident in the case of global capitalism and its impact upon the divided formation of Asian American constituencies. This division is between those who can profitably exploit the mobility of capital in global capitalism (the transnational capitalist subject who delights in travel) and those who are exploited by such mobility—the migrant, poor, or undocumented laborer whose mobility is not so much voluntary as compelled by circumstance and necessity. Aihwa Ong has termed the transnational capitalist subject a model of “flexible citizenship” who engages with the mobility of capitalism willingly. Ong argues, counter to some usual assumptions, that for these transnational subjects “flexibility, migration, and relocations, instead of being coerced or resisted,

have become practices to strive for rather than stability” (*Flexible Citizenship* 51). Flexibility enables economic survival, the ability to maximize the individual’s opportunities in a world of mobile capital and corporations. The issue of free choice and its definition becomes critical in dividing this class of flexible citizenship from its other, compulsorily mobile aliens. Within Asian America, both deterritorialized populations are found, people who are mobile by choice through the exploitation of their capital and people who are mobile by circumstance through the exploitation of their labor. Often, although not always, this division correlates with a domestic division between the model minority and their opposites, the “bad subjects” of the American body politic.³⁹ Asian American intellectuals, who generally align themselves with transnational labor and the nonmodel minority, form the population of bad subjects by choice.

In some cases, the flexible citizens from Asia, transplanted to America, “make whiteness a more problematic concept in the era of globalization,” a racial transformation with contradictory effects, including those upon the model minority (Ong, *Flexible Citizenship* 109). As a significant new component of the model minority, these flexible citizens participate in the transformation of the meaning of whiteness in its symbolic register. Through their arrival with wealth, Ong argues, Asian immigrant capitalists weaken the dominance of traditional whiteness (defined through European descent), which is dependent upon pluralism and gradual assimilation. In this model of traditional whiteness, nonwhite immigrants are supposed to gradually work their way up the socioeconomic ladder and move more closely to approximating whiteness with the passage of generations. The sudden appearance of wealthy Asians displaces this assumption that traditional whiteness is associated with wealth and that both whiteness and wealth are to be earned over the passage of time. By putting traditional whiteness into crisis, the new Asian capital also puts Asian America as a whole—not just the model minority—into crisis in its efforts to claim a domestic authenticity that does not threaten whites. Asian Americans may fear guilt by racial association with these wealthy new Asian immigrants and may also fear guilt by association with cheap and possibly undocumented migrant labor.⁴⁰ Together, the dangers of Asian foreign labor and capital are reprised in the dominant American imagination as a return of the “yellow peril.” The perennial status of Asian Americans as foreigners haunts Asian American efforts to retain a place in the American body politic and compels the nationalist, assimilatory drive of Asian Americans even more vigorously. The conflict over (de) territorialization signifies the consequences of the ideological choices that Asian America makes between nationalist and global identities. While a nationalist identity entails difficulties in confronting the racial problematic of multiculturalism and racially defined American identity, it allows the opportunity for a cohesive political identity with clearly articulated goals. Globalization in contrast

allows a challenge to racially defined American identities but also promotes the mobility of capital, which offers contradictory socioeconomic opportunities for different Asian ethnic and class populations.

These differences of possibility under global capitalism are not expressed purely economically but also in terms of ethnic and cultural divisions that threaten to fracture Asian America internally. These fractures are not due so much to an Old World legacy of conflicts between nations of origin but to contemporary conflicts over equitable political and economic representation within Asian America. A contestatory ideological position for Asian American intellectuals, which focuses on domestic inequality within an international frame that concerns historical American imperialism and the ongoing impact of global capitalism, seeks to be inclusive of all Asian American ethnic groups and their vastly different histories. This position contrasts with multiculturalism's version of Asian America that reproduces the rhetoric of pluralism and undercuts the importance of equitable economic representation—however that can be defined. This position faces difficulties in accounting for the vastly different histories of Asian Americans, which position Asian American ethnic groups unequally in the contest over resources and representation. Multiculturalism's seemingly clear benefit for Asian Americans is that it has displaced the black-white dualism of American race relations, introducing instead racial multiplicity and the possibility of an Asian American position in American politics and culture. A good case can be made, however, for the fact that polarization still exercises a strong, if symbolic, influence in the American imagination and will continue to do so in the future. That polarization aligns race and class, so that black and white are symbolic signifiers of exclusion and inclusion. Multiculturalism does not fundamentally change the economic terms of equality and inequality in the United States but instead proposes the equivalent of a racial face-lift on the American body politic, as many critics have already established.⁴¹ In the continuing polarization of American society around the symbolic oppositions of white and black, Asian America will, in the near future at least, be divided domestically between the model minority and the bad subject. This domestic division is matched by an overlapping global division between flexible citizens and compulsorily mobile aliens, with domestic citizens caught ambivalently in between. At the juncture of these voluntary and compulsory identifications stands the mainstream Asian American intellectual class, which must combine a theoretical agenda that is oppositional to global capitalism and domestic race/ class stratification with a valid assessment of the multiple and contradictory practices of Asian Americans in general. Not surprisingly, these practices reveal that Asian America is an often willing and enthusiastic participant in global capitalism, racial domination, and class stratification.

ASIAN AMERICAN BODIES POLITIC

Within Asian American literature, we find a history of representations of the body that provide evidence for the speculations in the previous section. In the rest of the book, I hope to provide an account of how these representations of the body constitute a form of political consciousness about the Asian American body politic that is an important source of influence on the rest of Asian American intellectual thought. The book itself is marked by a tension between, on the one hand, the plurality of bodies and the flexibility of authorial strategies found in the texts and, on the other, the relative rigidity of Asian American theoretical assumptions that has been stressed in this introduction. This is because Asian American studies has generally found itself engaged in a dialectic with American racism, whereby that racism's compulsion to represent Asian Americans as either dangerous (the bad subject) or docile (the model minority) has compelled an equal and opposite reaction on the part of critics, who vociferously reject the model minority stereotype but end up prioritizing and idealizing Asian America as a bad subject that is dangerous because it is politically resistant and oppositional. While Asian American literature has worked under the shadow of the same racism, it has been more ambivalent about the appropriate response, demonstrated in the flexibility that almost all the texts included in this book show as they fluctuate between resistance and accommodation, avoiding, for the most part, evaluating resistance or accommodation either positively or negatively, as Asian American critics are wont to do.⁴² At the same time, this plurality and flexibility does not exist absolutely; it must be read, received, interpreted, marketed, purchased, and, in general, "used" ideologically by readers and critics who are members of not only a literary public but also a wider American public permeated by racial attitudes and global capitalism. Therefore, this plurality and flexibility demonstrated historically is, in the *contemporary* moment, overwritten by the commodification of Asian American culture, the transformation of Asian American identity into a fairly homogeneous product for consumption that reaffirms the ideological location of Asian Americans in American culture for other Americans and supplements an Asian American lifestyle for Asian American consumers.

Asian American intellectuals have yet to confront this problem of commodification, which is a feature of the unstable equilibrium that Omi and Winant argue characterizes race relations today; rather, Asian American intellectuals implicitly disavow that they are implicated in the problem of commodification, and the theoretical consequences are manifest in their reliance upon a discourse of the bad subject (a discourse that I shall treat in my conclusion). A recognition of such complicity would entail an acknowledgment that Asian American identity may no longer be adequate in pursuing

the *long-term* radical political goals that are the generally (if vaguely) professed consensus of Asian American intellectuals but probably is adequate in pursuing the *short-term* goals of a middle-class-based project of nationalist assimilation into a capitalist society. While Asian American identity is, in short, not completely determined by capitalism and capitalism itself is not totalizing, the possibilities of social and political change offered by Asian American identity are limited, precisely because that change is now routed through a commodified identity. As a consequence, it could be argued that if contemporary capitalism has succeeded in transforming Asian American identity into a commodity, despite Asian America's diversity, then the Asian American intellectual tendency toward an equally flattening, bifurcated response—resistance or accommodation—may be adequate. This is not true, however, primarily because such a response denies the possibility that change, however limited, can be enacted through the commodity. Such a response prefers an idealized vision of radical change less compromised by capitalism. This idealized vision, again, is a disavowal of the less than idealized position of Asian American academics and many other intellectuals who themselves choose to enact change institutionally. By bringing these issues up, I seek not to be merely negative but instead to point out the limits of Asian America and, within those limits, what types of change can be enacted. Those limits are, in summary, the implicit pluralism found in contemporary constructions of Asian American identity, the commodification of that racial identity, the ideological heterogeneity of a diverse Asian American population, and the willingness of a considerable portion of that population to participate in and perpetuate such commodification and the social and economic practices that lead to it. By recognizing these limits and by encouraging a move to dissensus rather than consensus, we can deliberately bring ourselves into a moment of crisis, disrupting the equilibrium of racial identity and its commodification that we have begun to take for granted. By doing so, we can more clearly articulate our political goals and move toward other constructions of political identity that would be more useful in furthering these goals.

In chapter 1, turning toward the origins of Asian American literature at the end of the last century, we can recognize that even then, at another moment of equilibrium when the situation of Asian Americans was much more dire than today, there was a lack of consensus regarding the cultural and political options faced by Asian Americans. The situation of the Eaton sisters, the first Asian American writers, serves as a kind of parable about these options and their consequences. Edith and Winnifred, half-Chinese and half-English, wrote under the pen names Sui Sin Far and Onoto Watanna, respectively, and lived and worked in Canada and the United States. Edith assumed a Chinese authorial persona and Winnifred a Japanese one. Their respective strategies, personas, and reception offer us two enduring cultural positions that are still the basis of Asian American cultural

work today and will be in the near future. Sui Sin Far's confrontational persona explicitly contested inequalities of race, class, and gender and was clearly aligned with the Asian American as bad subject, embodied in the lives of Chinese immigrants, particularly women and children. Onoto Watanna's persona focused on the lives of Asians, in this case Japanese women, as quaint foreigners who occasionally ventured into the United States, where they were capable of assimilation (in small numbers) with whites. In the Eatons' work, we can see that Asian American literature has always been concerned with not just racial identity but gender and sexuality as well; the Eaton sisters, as do all the writers I consider, stage the relationship of the Asian American body politic to the American body politic through concerns about gender and sexuality. Thus the term "body politic" becomes useful in this book because it indicates the political importance of all facets of the body, not just its racialized dimension.

For both the Eaton sisters, then, the body politic belonged to women and children as much as it did to men, and stories of families and romances were critical to depicting this body politic. The Eatons' differences in identity, however, are equally important to discuss. Onoto Watanna passed as both Japanese and white, depending on occasion, and her survival and popularity, in contrast to her sister's demise and obscurity, remain as lessons in the costs and benefits of particular strategies oriented around the body politic, which assumed a hybrid form in the Eaton sisters' personal lives and literary work. In the Eaton sisters' choices, we may see an uncanny resemblance to the choices offered to contemporary Asian American authors: accommodation to the fetishization of a domesticated ethnic identity and resistance through assuming the threatening guise of an oppositional racial identity. Constructing their choices in this fashion, however, already presupposes a value assumption that concerns the political and ethical meaning of accommodation and resistance. It is not only the stories of the Eaton sisters that are important in discussing early representations of the body politic, therefore, but also critical, contemporary interpretations of their work that are implicitly based on assumptions about the contemporary Asian American body politic, projected retrospectively. Our concerns about racial identity and class politics in the contemporary moment, in other words, can shape our reconstruction of our past and intellectual lineage as one of subversion and resistance against racial and class domination. The contemporary criticism of the Eaton sisters exhibits a tendency that is common to Asian American studies, valuing subversion and resistance or examining the past for signs of subversion and resistance in unlikely places. Thus it is important to acknowledge that a figure such as Onoto Watanna deserves to be recovered not because she may be resistant but because she may be

compliant. Compliancy and accommodation are flexible strategies that were *and remain* important political choices for Asian Americans that are overlooked by assumptions about Asian American identity as being inherently, or desirably, oppositional.

In [chapter 2](#), the issues of resistance and accommodation in a moment of equilibrium marked by violent racial domination continue with the depression- era and post–World War II work of Carlos Bulosan and John Okada. In their books, *America Is in the Heart* and *No-No Boy*, respectively, the Asian American body politic is explicitly a masculine, wounded one struggling with the damage inflicted by American racism, which distorts the sexuality and gender identity of Asian American men. Through their use of irony, Bulosan and Okada demonstrate an awareness of the hypocrisies of American society, especially around race, and the limits of confrontation with such hypocrisies in the pre–civil rights era. Their protagonists, however, are trapped within those limits of what is allowable in the public discourse of American democracy; in this discourse, even if one believes that the United States is responsible for crimes against racial minorities, one also believes that American democracy and American culture provide the resolution and the healing for such crimes. This discourse of American exceptionalism works hand in hand with U.S. self-representation during World War II and the Cold War, when the United States presents itself to its constituents and the world as the defender of freedom and democracy. Only by stepping outside the boundaries of the United States in his little-known novel *The Cry and the Dedication* can Bulosan imagine another set of possibilities than that offered by American nationalism. Set in the Philippines amid the Communist-led Huk rebellion of the 1950s, *The Cry and the Dedication* rejects the discourse of American nationalism and exceptionalism, presenting a Filipino manhood restored by violent revolution. The open call to revolution against oppressive Filipino elites and the American neocolonialist enterprise in the Philippines marks *The Cry and the Dedication* as a novel ahead of its time during the 1950s. Ignored and forgotten until now, *The Cry and the Dedication* is a foreshadowing of the more confrontational 1960s.

In the 1960s, the state of equilibrium in U.S. racial relations was brought to crisis by the civil rights movement and its offspring, the racial empowerment movements. The work of Frank Chin and Gus Lee constitutes a second act to the discourse of Asian American masculinity initiated by Bulosan and Okada. Publishing after the 1968 watermark of Asian American consciousness, Chin and Lee argue that masculinity and American identity can be reclaimed through violence. The violence proposed by Chin and Lee is an attempt to meet the masculine, dominant American body politic, mythologically defined through frontier violence, on its own terms. Chin and Lee’s work, although published from the 1970s through the 1990s, is born out of experiences prior to 1968 and transformed by the events of that year. As a result, their fiction belongs to the first phase, broadly defined, of Asian American

literature that is produced in or from the era of alienation and is, to some extent, the climax of that period (1882–1943/1965).⁴³ In this climax, the alienation from American society that characterizes Asian American experience as a product of violent racial domination is gradually terminated. Asian Americans gain more political rights and more political and cultural visibility—in short, they increase their ability to lay claim to an American identity from which they had been excluded. In the age of alienation, therefore, the work of the Eaton sisters, Bulosan, Okada, Chin, and Lee—with the remarkable exception of *The Cry and the Dedication*—shares a similar territorial framework oriented around the nation, the cohesiveness of national identities, and the possibilities of or limitations to assimilation into an American national identity.

The new phase of racial equilibrium that ensues in the 1970s is marked by both this continuing territorial effort to solidify the claim to an American national identity and the beginnings of a postnational, deterritorialized identity. In the literature of the age of alienation, for example, while there are clear concerns with Asia in the work of the authors I consider, Asia usually functions as either the beginning of immigration or a place that is clearly delineated from the United States. In the literature that is published after the 1970s, the role of Asia in immigration, economy, and war, as represented in literary works, becomes much more important. This is a product, at least partially, of the radical changes brought about by the new immigration law of 1965, which allowed into the United States a much more diverse range of Asian immigrants, who carried with them the memory of their homelands and their experiences there. Even as post-1970s literature records these homeland experiences, it also serves a function in the new era of equilibrium, by consolidating—or by being forced to consolidate—a renewed sense of American exceptionalism after the failure of the Vietnam War, this time in the age of global capitalism. One of the most important representations of the Asian American body politic in the post-Vietnam War period is that of the victim. Historically, the role of the victim is one of the few “sympathetic” representations of Asians and Asian Americans in dominant American discourse. Subsequent to the Vietnam War, the representation of the victim assumes particular importance as a mode of rendering Asians visible. The autobiographical writings of Le Ly Hayslip exemplify this representation of the Asian American body politic as a victimized one. Her work is also important in its rejection of national identity, illustrating instead a body and identity located in mobility between nations and categories. Through representing herself as a victim of the ideological conflict between capitalism and communism, Hayslip both criticizes American hypocrisies and placates American sensibilities through a rehabilitated humanism. Her efforts lead her American readership to a sense of reconciliation with the traumatic past and enable the U.S. economy to resume business as usual through its search for new markets and new labor, this time in Vietnam.

The discourse of victimization and the status of the Vietnam War in the American imagination allow Vietnamese voices to attain a certain limited stature in American discourse. In contrast to Vietnam, the Philippines occupies the antithetical place in the American imagination. Whereas Vietnam has been highly visible, the Philippines has been relatively ignored, not even granted the acknowledgment of being a victim of American imperialism. It is the fact of the Philippines' obscurity in relation to its prominent role in the development of American imperialism that makes it critical. Ninotchka Rosca and Jessica Hagedorn, American-based writers, set their novels outside the United States, in the Philippines themselves, and deploy queer bodies as metaphoric signifiers of the relationship between the Philippines and the United States. The Philippines are, so to speak, "in the closet" when it comes to American history. While Rosca examines the culturally specific traditions of transvestites in the Philippines, Hagedorn looks at the practices of modernized, Westernized urban gay men in Manila; in both cases, transvestites and gay men become involved in the revolution against state dictatorship. In these novels, then, queer sexual practices, whether they are "traditional" or "Western," become allegories for struggle against a neocolonial dictatorship (sponsored by the United States) that also assumes a heterosexual, patriarchal cast. These novels seek to criticize the invisibility of Filipinos in the United States and American history, an invisibility that consolidates the American mythology of democratic exceptionalism and further stabilizes American equilibrium. This condition of equilibrium is concerned not only with racial relations but with international relations of economics and politics as well; to the extent that the United States considers itself the defender of the free, capitalist world, it must also believe in a domestic rhetoric of pluralist inclusion and equality, where racial inequality is an aberration rather than a structural flaw.

Hayslip, Rosca, and Hagedorn all pose challenges to the dominant nationalist, assimilationist model of Asian American literature, found in both fiction and criticism and premised upon the ideology of American pluralism. The characters and subjects in these works are transnational, not deeply concerned with the sovereignty of nations as ultimate horizons of possibility for their identifications, and not focused upon the necessity of claiming American identity. They also are produced from nations whose historic relationships to the United States have been characterized by both a deep mutual antagonism and a one-sided patronization by the United States. These characters and subjects thus introduce the history of American imperialism into Asian American studies. The victim and the queer are two particular representations used by American imperialism—and domestic racism—to depict its objects of domination. The victim appeals to a lingering sense of American guilt, while the queer is suitable only for the closet. These two forms of the Asian American body politic are a direct function of American intervention overseas and immigration reforms at home that have transformed

the size and diversity of Asian America, allowing for new and contradictory variations of the Asian American body politic in its relationship to the American body politic.

In the conclusion, I argue that the basic pattern of contradiction in terms of how Asian America relates to the American body politic is exemplified in the binary choices of identification that dominant American discourse offers to Asian Americans, which Asian Americans have adapted to some extent: the model minority and the bad subject. As the term suggests, the model minority is living testimony to the possibilities of assimilation and upward mobility that America holds out to immigrants and racial minorities. The model minority serves a particular ideological purpose in America's self-representation as a land of opportunity, disciplining *nonmodel* minorities whose lack of success would therefore seem to be due to their own meager desires, skills, or resources, rather than being due to racial discrimination or class oppression. Asian American intellectuals who have written on the model minority unanimously agree on its pernicious ideological uses and create in opposition what I call a discourse of the bad subject, which both appropriates the dominant representation of Asian Americans as a dangerous and subversive population and idealizes Asian America as a site of political opposition and resistance. In the conclusion, I trouble this binary of model minority and bad subject by examining the processes of generalization and idealization that the discourse of the bad subject engages in, processes that are embodied in Cynthia Kadohata's novel *In the Heart of the Valley of Love*. Theresa Cha's *Dictee* and its relationship with a companion volume, Elaine H. Kim and Norma Alarcón's *Writing Self, Writing Nation*, illustrate a more complex enactment of the discourse of the bad subject. Despite the sophisticated tools and brilliant insights of the critics of *Writing Self, Writing Nation, Dictee* manages to exceed their interpretations through both its representation of identity as fluid and its own inflexibility as a text, which results in a resistance to critical exegesis. Fluidity and inflexibility, leading to resistance, are the emblems of Asian America's relationship to its intellectuals. Finally, I read Lois-Ann Yamanaka's novels, not as examples of Asian American literature but as examples of a local literature of Hawai'i that has been claimed by Asian Americans. Given this context, I read her depictions of the local community as an analogy for the continental Asian American community and argue that the world Yamanaka depicts, where Asian identity is taken for granted, allowing for the possibility of interethnic and interclass strife among Asian populations, is the future of Asian America.

If this world of strife is a possibility for Asian America, then perhaps the viability of Asian America as a political category with a clear ideological orientation is doomed. This is a critical issue that Asian American intellectuals must confront, the end of Asian American reality as they now see it. By considering the possibilities raised by this issue we can define the practice and potential of the

contemporary Asian American body politic. While the future of Asian America is unpredictable in its detail and while projections may constitute arrogance, they are also necessary to some extent as we think about the potential consequences of our contemporary assumptions and strategies about Asian American community and politics.⁴⁴ At the contemporary moment, Asian America seems to be struggling to define an autonomous identity separate from the polar oppositions of blackness and whiteness; as David Palumbo-Liu puts it, “The nature of Asian American social subjectivity now vacillates between whiteness and color” (5). While such an autonomous identity may more accurately reflect the racial composition of the United States, therefore enabling a more effective analysis of social, political, and economic relations, it also reflects the contemporary understanding of racial formation and the racial state, which has helped to create and certainly perpetuate these racial identifications that are far from “natural.” Within the terms of racial formation and the racial state, in other words, the struggle for Asian American autonomy is legitimate and indeed useful, but they are also the terms that Asian America frequently takes for granted as its intellectual and political horizon.

As an added consideration, we should also not ignore the possibility that the idea of autonomy may ultimately be ineffective in addressing the persisting symbolic division of the nation into black and white. While the creation of an autonomous Asian American identity will inevitably heighten the importance of multiculturalism in recognizing American diversity, this does not necessarily mean that the historically marginalized status of blackness and the historically privileged status of whiteness will not continue to serve as symbolic embodiments of failure and achievement for Americans, especially immigrants. As Herbert Gans argues provocatively, while the past and contemporary states of American racial and economic relations have been symbolically divided between white and nonwhite, the future may entail the continuing division of the nation into black and nonblack; in the case of Asian Americans specifically, Palumbo-Liu argues in a similar fashion that Asian Americans may be “negatively articulated” with whites, that is, against blacks (4).⁴⁵ An autonomous Asian American identity then furthers the Asian American claim to legitimacy in the nation by denying affiliations with blackness; it is a position that troubles founding notions of Asian American identity, and it is a position that Asian American intellectuals may not be able to prevent Asian America from assuming as its dominant—if not sole—mode of representation.

More problematic, and equally probable, is the internal division of Asian America, despite its own diversity, between the symbolic poles of black and non-black, into bad subject and model minority, a division enacted not only by dominant society but also by Asian American intellectuals. This is a division that is important both to Asian American self-perception—because Asian Americans are capable of constructing ethnic hierarchies and practicing discrimination—and to the perception of

Asian Americans by the general American public. Asian America seems to believe that an American recognition of its claim to autonomy means that there will be a corollary increase in American racial sophistication concerning the real diversity of the nation, and that sophistication entails sympathy to economic and political inequality. The equally possible corollary to sophistication, however, is the ability on the part of other Americans to distinguish between those Asian Americans who are assimilable and those who are not. In reaction, Asian American intellectuals may seek to do what Mari Matsuda and Frank Chin advocate in their differing ways: to divide the Asian American population in an ideological fashion, into the “real” Asian Americans and the fake ones, the bad subjects and the model minorities. We may fall into what Judith Butler, in *Bodies That Matter*, describes as “the despair evident in some forms of identity politics . . . marked by the elevation and regulation of identity positions as a primary political policy” (117). In this scenario, with so much at stake, Asian Americans must make ethical choices that concern their alliances and alignments, as well as their identity and its consequences. Ironically, as we shall see in the next chapter, Asian America has not advanced as greatly as it has imagined in the past hundred years concerning these ethical choices and political commitments. Indeed, the ethical, moral, and political choices contemporary Asian Americans face bear an all too familiar resemblance to those that confronted the first pioneers of Asian American identity at the end of the last century.